

The Nimble Nibs

Field	Value
Tier	2
Party Level	Five independent 6th-level characters
Duration	2–2.5 hours; up to 3 hours with every lead and the optional encounter
Setting	Bellwether, independent canal city (DM ADDITION)
Hook From	Standalone; no prior session assumed



Adventure Summary

During Bellwether's Festival of Small Wonders, a coordinated troupe of goblin pickpockets steals purses, keys, and personal belongings under cover of street theater. The thefts are real and disruptive: medicine, a wedding ring, and a treasured locket are among the missing property. The culprits, **the Nimble Nibs**, intended to return most personal objects after using them as props in a final caper. Their true goal is to recover a puppet trunk from the Festival Guild's secured prop annex and regain their impounded wagon, but their leader has buried that reasonable need beneath an unreasonable plan.

The party can solve the case through clues, social pressure, surveillance, magic, or direct pursuit. A successful ending must address both halves of the problem: victims need restitution, and the goblins need a lawful alternative to theft. Arrest, exile, cover-up, public audition, and negotiated community service are all supported outcomes.

Running This Session

- **Tone:** Fast, colorful, and comic without treating victims' losses as harmless.
- **Pacing:** Run Act I, Scene 1.2 as a clue-selection montage. Use only two witnesses if time is tight. Run Act III, Scene 3.2 as a 5–10 minute debrief.
- **Failure:** Never gate progress behind one roll. Failed checks add complications, public alarm, or weaker leverage; visible evidence still points forward.
- **Violence:** Encounter 1 is optional. The Nimble Nibs use nonlethal attacks and flee or surrender quickly. They are offenders, not murderous villains.
- **Magic:** Divination and detection magic can accelerate the investigation. Reward useful spell expenditure with direct information rather than adding false wards.
- **Independent continuity:** Bellwether and its cast are DM additions. Nothing here depends on Talthryn, Caer Aldreth, or Session 1.

Core Cast

NPC	Public role	Table cue
Guildmaster Osric Pindle	Festival Guildmaster and first complainant	Inflates every indignity; becomes precise when his key is mentioned
Sergeant Mina Cobble	Canal Watch investigator	Dry humor; prioritizes vulnerable victims and proportionate justice
Tessa Thimblewick	Flower seller and witness	Excited storyteller; protective of the smallest goblin
Clerk Barnaby Quill	Municipal impound clerk	Hides behind forms; wants a face-saving legal solution
Maestro Nibs	Goblin troupe leader	Frames every exchange as an act in a grand production
Skritch “Quickpocket”	Troupe choreographer and escape artist	Competitive; protects younger performers
Fizzwick	Troupe effects operator	Nervous; stage smoke escapes whenever he lies
Adjudicator Amara Vale	Festival performance judge	Practical; bends procedure for a safe, popular solution

Victim and Property Ledger

Victim	Missing property	Priority	Current location
Osric Pindle	Jeweled purse, 40 gp, Festival Guild prop-annex key, authorization token	Key is case-critical	Catalogued in troupe cellar
Tessa Thimblewick	Silver locket	Sentimental	Skritch's costume pocket
Apothecary Vell	One day's heart medicine	Urgent	Fizzwick's return basket
Mara and Dain Lute	Wedding ring	Sentimental	Inside a marionette's hollow crown
Pip Crumble	One custard pie	Minor	Consumed during rehearsal

Returning the medicine, ring, and locket is Mina's minimum condition for a peaceful resolution. Osric's 40 gp, key, token, and purse must also be restored before the Guild can issue a license.

Act I — Light Fingers at Lantern Market

Act I, Scene 1.1 — The Pompous Victim

Purpose / transition: Establish the thefts, identify the stakes, and give the party three ways into the investigation: the coordinated routine, the Festival Guild key, or the theft route.

Setting

- **Location:** Lantern Market, a broad plaza divided by canals and crossed by small arched bridges.
- **See:** Bright awnings, painted barges, street magicians, overturned baskets, and Osric standing on a crate before an unimpressed crowd.
- **Hear:** Vendors competing for customers, canal bells, laughter when Osric reenacts the theft, and mutually contradictory witness accounts.
- **Smell:** Citrus peel, fried dough, canal water, lamp oil, and cut flowers.
- **Sense:** Investigation proficiency or thieves' tools experience identifies a coordinated distraction-and-lift routine. *Detect Magic* finds fading illusion magic on a dropped card bearing a painted thimble emblem; the magic is a harmless sound effect, not a tracking aura.

NPCs

Guildmaster Osric Pindle

- **Disposition going in:** Indignant and presumptuous; he treats any competent-looking adventurer as hired help.
- **Motivations:** Recover his purse and Guild key, conceal how thoroughly he was fooled, and turn the incident into support for stricter performer licensing.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Sergeant Mina Cobble

- **Disposition going in:** Amused by Osric, professionally concerned about the pattern.
- **Motivations:** Recover all property, prevent panic or collective blame, and resolve the matter without unnecessary injury.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Meaningful choices: Protect Osric's dignity or leverage his embarrassment; prioritize the Guild key or vulnerable victims; work under Mina's oversight or independently.

Encounter: None

Conditional follow-through:

If Act I, Scene 1.1 ended with Osric revealing the Guild key: In Act II, Scene 2.1, Barnaby immediately connects it to the secured prop annex.

If Act I, Scene 1.1 ended with a public alarm: Witnesses in Act I, Scene 1.2 require reassurance before volunteering details, and Niblet warns the troupe.

Otherwise: The Nimble Nibs initially treat the investigation as an entertaining rival performance.

Transition: Move to Act I, Scene 1.2 once the party has the theft map, thimble emblem, or victim list. If none was secured, Mina points out flour prints leading from the plaza.

Act I, Scene 1.2 — Three Clues and a Custard Pie

Purpose / transition: Run a compact investigation montage. Let the party choose two of three clue stations; any two reveal the Old Puppet Quarter and either the impound yard or troupe emblem.

Setting

- **Location:** The market theft route: Tessa's flower stall, Pip's pastry cart, and an arched bridge used by buskers.
- **See:** Chalk arrows at goblin eye level, a snapped marionette string, tiny boot prints in flour, and a custard pie tin beneath a bench.
- **Hear:** A hurdy-gurdy repeating the same phrase, vendors arguing over details, and occasional giggling from an upper window.
- **Smell:** Vanilla custard, crushed mint, wet rope, and cheap stage powder.
- **Sense:** DC 13 Investigation or Survival reconstructs several goblins moving in formation. *Detect Magic* identifies a minor illusion embedded in the repeated tune. Passive Perception 15+ notices a goblin lookout reflected in a polished kettle.

NPCs

Tessa Thimblewick

- **Disposition going in:** Friendly and excited; cautious only if Act I, Scene 1.1 ended with a public alarm.
- **Motivations:** Recover her locket, tell an excellent story, and keep the smallest goblin from being hurt.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Pip Crumble

- **Disposition going in:** Defensive about the pastry-cart collision.
- **Motivations:** Avoid paying for ruined pies and conceal that the goblins purchased two pies before taking a third.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Goblin Lookout Niblet

- **Disposition going in:** Curious unless Act I, Scene 1.1 ended with a public alarm; then frightened.
- **Motivations:** Learn whether the party wants restitution, arrest, or a fight; warn the troupe if threatened.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Meaningful choices: Which witnesses to prioritize; whether to chase Niblet; whether to frame the investigation as punishment, restitution, or assistance.

Encounter: None

Conditional follow-through:

If Act I, Scene 1.2 ended with Tessa warning Niblet or a failed chase: In Act II, Scene 2.1, Niblet has removed the troupe playbill but left a fresh custard-and-sawdust trail.

If Act I, Scene 1.2 ended with Pip revealing the wagon: Barnaby begins Act II, Scene 2.1 at Helpful rather than Neutral when shown Mina's chit.

Otherwise: Chalk arrows and the evidence tag lead to the impound yard.

Transition: Proceed to Act II, Scene 2.1 when the party identifies the wagon, impound yard, Old Puppet Quarter, or thimble emblem.

Act II — The Method Behind the Mischief

Act II, Scene 2.1 — The Impound Yard Ledger

Purpose / transition: Reveal the coherent target behind the theft: the Guild prop-annex key opens the secured annex where the troupe's registered puppet trunk was moved after its wagon was impounded. Establish a lawful solution.

Setting

- **Location:** Bellwether Municipal Impound Yard beside the Festival Guild's secured prop annex.
- **See:** A brightly painted puppet wagon behind a municipal wheel clamp, citation notices across its doors, a stone annex with a brass Guild lock, and clerks chasing a goat wearing an evidence tag.
- **Hear:** Paper rustling, stamp thumps, wagon-wheel squeaks, the goat's bell, and muffled movement inside the wagon.
- **Smell:** Dust, old canvas, sealing wax, hay, and damp wood.
- **Sense:** DC 12 Investigation confirms the wheel clamp and annex lock use different mechanisms. If Osric disclosed the key in Act I, Scene 1.1, its crest matches the annex lock. DC 13 Insight reveals Barnaby is embarrassed by a misfiled permit, not hostile to goblins.

NPCs

Clerk Barnaby Quill

- **Disposition going in:** Neutral and procedural; Helpful if Act I, Scene 1.2 ended with Pip's evidence and the party presents Mina's chit.
- **Motivations:** Preserve civic procedure, conceal that the wagon was impounded under the wrong subsection, collect a defensible fee, and make the goat someone else's problem.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Niblet

- **Disposition going in:** Hidden in the wagon; curious if the party emphasized restitution, frightened if earlier scenes ended with alarm or pursuit.
- **Motivations:** Protect the troupe, recover the puppet trunk, and judge whether the party can carry a lawful offer to Maestro Nibs.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Meaningful choices: Expose Barnaby's error or offer him a face-saving correction; pay, negotiate, or reject the release terms; use Niblet as a bridge or pursue them as a suspect.

Encounter: None

Conditional follow-through:

If Act II, Scene 2.1 ended with a legal release path: Maestro Nibs begins Act II, Scene 2.2 hopeful; one successful DC 13 social check can secure a provisional agreement.

If Act II, Scene 2.1 ended with Niblet frightened or Barnaby robbed: The troupe begins Act II, Scene 2.2 defensive; the first social check is DC 16, and Encounter 1 is primed.

If Act II, Scene 2.1 ended with Barnaby summoning the Watch: Mina arrives in Act III, Scene 3.1 with the case still open.

Otherwise: The party reaches the cellar with evidence but no ready legal solution.

Transition: Move to Act II, Scene 2.2 when the party obtains the rehearsal location from Niblet, the schedule, or the playbill ledger.

Act II, Scene 2.2 — Rehearsal Beneath the Crooked Curtain

Purpose / transition: Confront the Nimble Nibs, recover the property, and decide whether the finale begins with cooperation, capture, or pursuit.

Setting

- **Location:** A disused cellar theater beneath the Crooked Curtain tavern.
- **See:** Painted flats, marionettes, crossing ropes, labeled baskets of stolen property, flour sacks, ladders, and goblins rehearsing pocket-lifting as choreography.
- **Hear:** Whispered counting, puppet clacks, a poorly tuned fiddle, and abrupt silence when the party is noticed.
- **Smell:** Greasepaint, candle wax, mushroom stew, sawdust, and old velvet.
- **Sense:** DC 12 Investigation shows valuables are catalogued rather than spent. DC 13 Insight reveals most troupe members are proud of their skill but uncomfortable with the thefts. *Locate Object* can identify any listed item unless it is inside the lead-lined stage safe; none initially are.

NPCs

Maestro Nibs

- **Disposition going in:** Hopeful if Act II, Scene 2.1 ended with a legal path; defensive if Niblet was frightened; otherwise grandiose and curious.
- **Motivations:** Recover the wagon and puppet trunk, keep the troupe together, and prove goblin performers deserve a festival place.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Skritch “Quickpocket”

- **Disposition going in:** Competitive and protective.
- **Motivations:** Keep younger goblins free, demonstrate her craft, and avoid admitting she kept Tessa's locket because she admired it.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Fizzwick

- **Disposition going in:** Nervous and ready to confess.
- **Motivations:** Return dangerous and sentimental items, save the wagon, and perform his exploding-turnip finale.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Meaningful choices: Demand arrest, negotiate restitution, sponsor an audition, permit exile, or accept the troupe's proposed public skills test.

Encounter: Encounter 1 — The Crooked Curtain Scramble (File 2), optional. Trigger only if negotiation fails, a character initiates force, immediate indiscriminate arrest is attempted, or the party chooses a forceful pursuit. The troupe uses nonlethal tactics and stops when any listed de-escalation condition is met.

Conditional follow-through:

If Act II, Scene 2.2 ended with agreement and full property recovery: Act III, Scene 3.1 is a provisional audition; Amara begins Neutral and Mina begins Helpful.

If Act II, Scene 2.2 ended with the troupe escaping: Act III, Scene 3.1 is a public pursuit folded into an unscheduled performance.

If Act II, Scene 2.2 ended with capture: Act III, Scene 3.1 is a civic hearing at the festival stage.

If Act II, Scene 2.2 ended with escape offered without restitution: Mina begins Hostile to that plan, and victims publicly present their claims.

Transition: Proceed to Act III, Scene 3.1 once the party has an agreement, prisoners, or a trail to the festival stage.

Act III — The Festival's Smallest Headliners

Act III, Scene 3.1 — The Festival Audition

Purpose / transition: Resolve guilt, restitution, and the troupe's future through a public audition, pursuit, or hearing.

Setting

- **Location:** Bellwether's Festival Stage beside the central canal.
- **See:** Colorful banners, a temporary stage, an expectant crowd, Osric's front-row chair, and the clamped puppet wagon across the canal.
- **Hear:** Festival bells, applause, officials debating permits, and goblins whispering about a missing finale puppet.
- **Smell:** Sugared almonds, river air, hot wax, fried onions, and stage smoke.
- **Sense:** DC 12 Insight shows the crowd wants permission to laugh rather than punishment. Performance proficiency or DC 13 social insight identifies Osric's public dignity as the main obstacle to compromise.

NPCs

Adjudicator Amara Vale

- **Disposition going in:** Neutral if a legal path exists; skeptical if property remains missing or the troupe arrives as fugitives.
- **Motivations:** Deliver a good festival, avoid scandal, and preserve enough procedure to keep her office credible.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Guildmaster Osric Pindle

- **Disposition going in:** Helpful if his key and dignity were restored quietly; Hostile if mocked or if the key is missing.
- **Motivations:** Recover property, control the public story, and avoid being the festival's punchline.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Sergeant Mina Cobble

- **Disposition going in:** Helpful after full restitution; Neutral after capture; Hostile if the party enabled escape without restitution or used excessive force.
- **Motivations:** Secure restitution, impose proportionate consequences, and avoid filling cells with performers.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Meaningful choices: Give Osric face-saving credit or expose him; advocate license, exile, or arrest; reveal or conceal the full theft record; put the party's reputation behind a public test.

Encounter: None

Conditional follow-through:

If Act III, Scene 3.1 ended with a license: The Nimble Nibs become legitimate performers and potential urban informants.

If Act III, Scene 3.1 ended with restitution but no license: The troupe leaves Bellwether with its wagon under a no-performance order.

If Act III, Scene 3.1 ended with imprisonment: Merchants approve; performers and poorer residents view the party less favorably.

If Act III, Scene 3.1 ended with a cover-up: The troupe is free, but Mina opens a quiet inquiry if any property remains missing.

Transition: Move to Act III, Scene 3.2 once Amara or Mina announces terms and the party accepts, rejects, or circumvents them.

Act III, Scene 3.2 — Pockets Emptied, Accounts Settled

Purpose / transition: Spend 5–10 minutes resolving rewards, property, relationships, and loose ends. This scene contains no new obstacle.

Setting

- **Location:** A canal-side café after the festival proceedings.
- **See:** Recovered possessions on numbered cloths, signed receipts, tired goblins sharing an enormous pastry, and the wagon departing, returning, or remaining clamped.
- **Hear:** Coins counted, victims thanking or complaining, sunset canal bells, and distant applause.
- **Smell:** Coffee, cinnamon, ink, damp stone, and cooling pastry.
- **Sense:** DC 12 Insight confirms Maestro intends to abandon theft if the troupe retains a livelihood. If humiliated and separated without an alternative, he instead plans to regroup elsewhere.

NPCs

Maestro Nibs

- **Disposition going in:** Grateful, chastened, resentful, imprisoned, or absent according to Act III, Scene 3.1.
- **Motivations:** Keep the troupe together, settle obligations, and preserve some theatrical dignity.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Sergeant Mina Cobble

- **Disposition going in:** Determined by the party's proportionality and restitution record.
- **Motivations:** Close the case accurately and prevent Osric from rewriting the entire event.
- **Possible outcomes and effects:**

Meaningful choices: Accept Osric's preferred public story; forgive or collect minor losses; invite the troupe as contacts; require a code of conduct.

Encounter: None

Conditional follow-through:

If Act III, Scene 3.2 ended with all priority possessions returned: The case closes without a serious victim left behind.

If Act III, Scene 3.2 ended with Osric repaid but vulnerable victims ignored: The party receives Osric's money but loses Mina's respect and civic reward.

If Act III, Scene 3.2 ended with a licensed troupe: The party gains the Nimble Nibs as a Bellwether information contact.

Otherwise: The troupe may recur as comic rivals with an improved technique and an unresolved moral debt.

Rewards

Reward	Condition	Value / effect
Osric's contract	Purse, key, token, and 40 gp returned	300 gp
Civic case reward	Peaceful resolution and priority restitution	Up to 200 gp
Recovered 40 gp	Inside Osric's purse	Must be returned to earn full contract
Honorary brass thimble badges ■■	Troupe licensed	Advantage on one future Charisma check with Bellwether street performers; consumed after use
Nimble Nibs contact	Troupe licensed or fairly exiled	Local rumors, performer access, and minor urban intelligence

No level-up occurs during the one-shot. If this session is inserted into a campaign as a milestone, apply advancement between sessions.

Resolution Checklist

- ☐ Osric's purse, key, token, and 40 gp accounted for
- ☐ Tessa's locket returned or deliberately left unresolved
- ☐ Apothecary Vell's medicine returned
- ☐ Mara and Dain's wedding ring returned
- ☐ Wagon: released, retained, confiscated, or abandoned
- ☐ Nimble Nibs: licensed, exiled, arrested, concealed, or escaped
- ☐ Mina's final disposition toward the party recorded
- ☐ Any cover-up or unpaid victim recorded as a loose end after play

The Nimble Nibs — Combat Tracker

Session 002 · DM combat tracker · Stat-block cards are text-only; the tactical map is last.

Encounter math — 5× **Level 6 PCs**. Easy 1,500 · Medium 3,000 · Hard 4,500 · Deadly 7,000. Encounter 1 has **1,100 raw XP**; six enemies apply the ×2 group multiplier for **2,200 adjusted XP**, an Easy encounter. It is intentionally nonlethal and should end through morale or negotiation before becoming a grind.

Encounter 1 — The Crooked Curtain Scramble

Act II, Scene 2.2 · Easy (1,100 raw XP; 2,200 adjusted XP / Easy threshold 1,500)

Field	Value
Location	Cellar puppet theater beneath the Crooked Curtain tavern
Light	Bright candlelight on stage; dim behind curtains
Terrain	Stage and ladders; hanging curtains; prop baskets; flour sacks; two trapdoors; stairs north; alley hatch south
Cover	Curtains grant concealment but not cover; prop trunks grant half cover
Hazards	Flour cloud, tangled marionette lines, and trapdoors are inconveniences only; no lethal stage hazards
Objective	Goblins escape together; PCs recover property or stop their flight
Stop conditions	Two goblins incapacitated; Maestro persuaded; priority property displayed; credible lawful release offered; all exits blocked without violence

Round: ☐1 ☐2 ☐3 ☐4 ☐5 ☐6 ☐7 ☐8 ☐9 ☐10

Init	Combatant	AC	HP	Notes
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
15	Maestro Nibs ■■	15	45 □□□□□□□□	Ringleader; asks for parley
15	Skritch Quickpocket ■■	15	45 □□□□□□□□	Ringleader; controls escape ropes
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
14	Goblin Performer ■■ A	14	13 □□□	Flour prop
14	Goblin Performer ■■ B	14	13 □□□	Net prop
14	Goblin Performer ■■ C	14	13 □□□	Curtain rope
14	Goblin Performer ■■ D	14	13 □□□	Property basket
—	_____	—	_____	_____

Init	Combatant	AC	HP	Notes
—	—	—	—	—

Conditions: Bln · Chr · Deaf · Frt · Grp · Inc · Inv · Prl · Pet · Pzn · Prn · Rst · Stn · Uns · Conc

Triggers & Countdowns

- **Start:** Only roll initiative if Act II, Scene 2.2 meets an explicit encounter trigger. Fizzwick's first smoke puff allows one final sentence of negotiation before round 1.
- **Round 1:** Skritch opens the alley hatch; one performer begins carrying the property basket toward it.
- **Round 2:** If no stop condition has occurred, Maestro calls for parley while moving toward the hatch.
- **Round 3:** Any mobile goblin adjacent to an exit escapes rather than attacking.
- **Morale:** When any two goblins are incapacitated, all remaining goblins surrender or disengage and offer restitution.
- **Nonlethal default:** Goblins declare attacks nonlethal where the rules allow. Their tricks deal little or no damage and never target unconscious creatures.

Tactics Summary

- **Maestro Nibs:** Directs allies, uses *Baton Feint*, then Dodges or Disengages; spends reactions to move endangered performers.
- **Skritch:** Uses *Tangle-Line* to restrain a pursuer, then Nimble Escape to reach an escape rope.
- **Goblin Performers:** One moves the property basket; others use flour, nets, Help, and Disengage. They do not focus fire.

Loot / Aftermath

- All ledgered stolen property is present in the cellar unless a prior scene explicitly moved an item.
- Costumes and props have no meaningful resale value; taking them undermines a negotiated resolution.
- Captured goblins immediately propose full restitution in exchange for staying together pending Mina's judgment.

Nimble Nibs Ringleader ■■

Small humanoid (goblinoid), chaotic neutral · CR 2 (450 XP)

AC 15 (studded costume) · **HP** 45 (10d6+10) · **Speed** 30 ft.

STR 9 (−1) · **DEX** 18 (+4) · **CON** 12 (+1) · **INT** 13 (+1) · **WIS** 12 (+1) · **CHA** 16 (+3)

Saves Dex +6, Cha +5 · **Skills** Acrobatics +6, Deception +5, Performance +5, Sleight of Hand +6 · **Senses** darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 11 · **Languages** Common, Goblin · **CR** 2

Traits

Nimble Escape. The ringleader can take the Disengage or Hide action as a bonus action.

Nonlethal Rehearsal. When the ringleader reduces a creature to 0 HP with a melee attack, the creature is stable and unconscious. The ringleader never attacks an unconscious target.

Role variation. Maestro uses *Baton Feint* first; Skritch uses *Tangle-Line* first. Statistics are otherwise identical.

Actions

Multiattack. The ringleader makes two Padded Baton attacks or one Padded Baton attack and uses Baton Feint.

Padded Baton. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 7 (1d6+4) bludgeoning.

Baton Feint (Maestro; Recharge 5–6). One creature within 30 feet that can see Maestro must succeed on a DC 13 Wisdom save or have disadvantage on its next attack before the end of its next turn. One goblin Maestro can see may move up to half its speed without provoking opportunity attacks.

Tangle-Line (Skritch; Recharge 5–6). *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, range 20/60 ft., one Large or smaller creature. On a hit, the target is restrained by marionette cord. A creature can use an action to make a DC 13 Strength (Athletics) or Dexterity (Acrobatics) check, freeing the target on a success. The cord has AC 10 and 5 HP.

Reactions

Places, Everyone! When a goblin within 30 feet is hit, the ringleader lets that goblin move 10 feet without provoking opportunity attacks, provided it can hear the ringleader.

Round-by-round tactics

Round 1: Maestro uses *Baton Feint* and moves toward center stage; Skritch uses *Tangle-Line* on the fastest pursuer and uses bonus-action movement toward an escape route.

Round 2: Both ask for parley. If refused, use padded batons only against creatures blocking an exit.

Round 3+: Disengage and escape. Use recharge abilities defensively. Reaction priority: move the most injured performer away from danger.

On-defeat loot: Costume purse with 3 gp and marked wooden audition tokens; stolen property is tracked separately.

Goblin Performer ■■

Small humanoid (goblinoid), chaotic neutral · CR 1/4 (50 XP)

AC 14 (leather costume) · **HP** 13 (3d6+3) · **Speed** 30 ft.

STR 8 (–1) · **DEX** 16 (+3) · **CON** 12 (+1) · **INT** 10 (+0) · **WIS** 10 (+0) · **CHA** 13 (+1)

Skills Acrobatics +5, Performance +3, Sleight of Hand +5 · **Senses** darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 10 · **Languages** Common, Goblin · **CR** 1/4

Traits

Nimble Escape. The performer can take the Disengage or Hide action as a bonus action.

Nonlethal Rehearsal. The performer uses harmless stage tools and never attacks an unconscious creature.

Actions

Padded Prop. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d4+3) bludgeoning.

Flour Puff (1/Day). A 10-foot cube within 20 feet fills with flour until the start of the performer's next turn. Creatures in it are lightly obscured. A creature entering it or starting there must succeed on a DC 11 Constitution save or be unable to take reactions until the start of its next turn due to coughing.

Stage Net (1/Day). *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, range 5/15 ft., one Large or smaller target. On a hit, the target is restrained. Escape DC 10; net AC 10, 5 HP.

Round-by-round tactics

Round 1: One carries the property basket; two use flour or nets; one uses Help for Skritch.

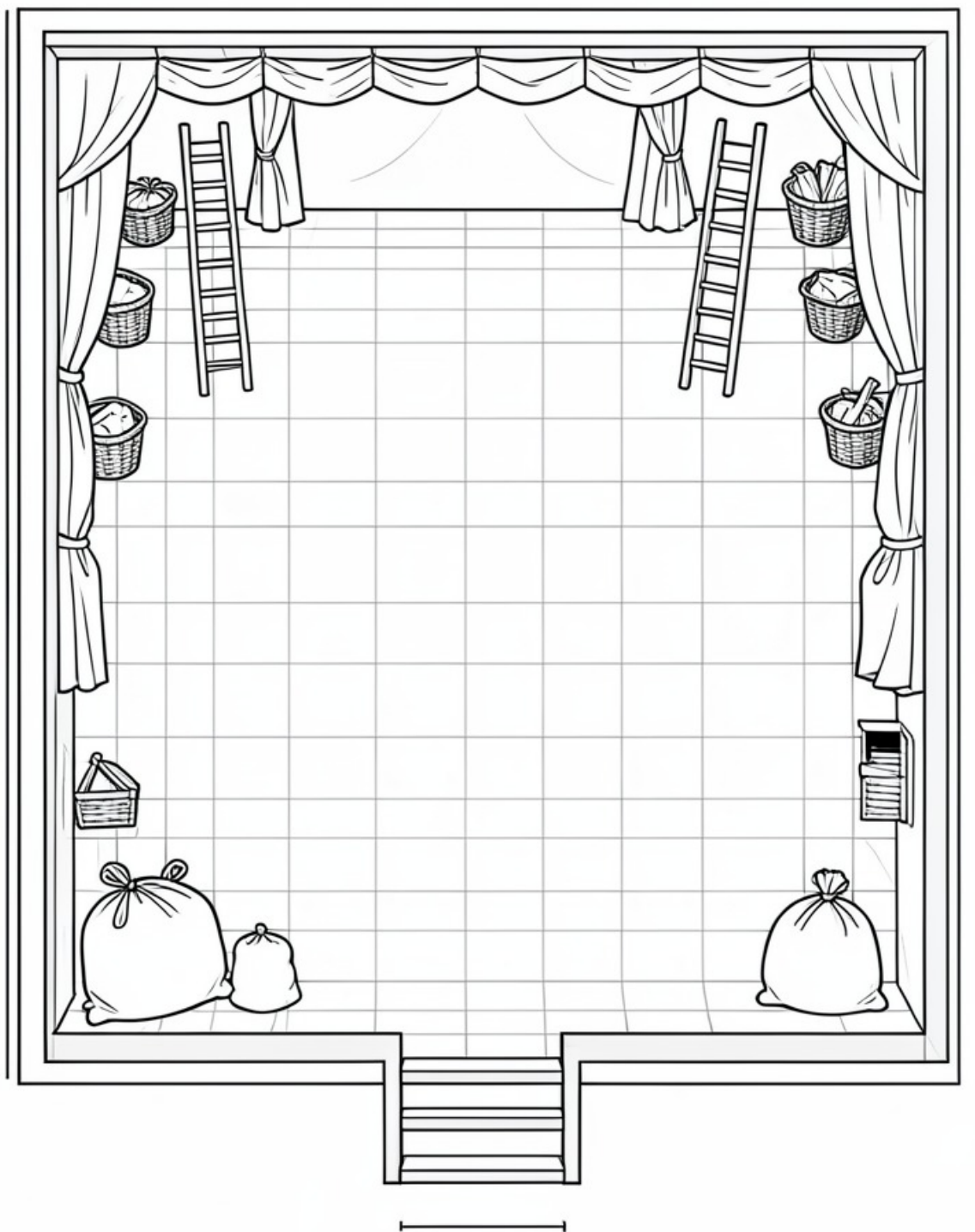
Round 2: Disengage toward exits. A performer drops the basket rather than fight for it.

Round 3+: Escape or surrender. No performer remains alone to cover a retreat.

On-defeat loot: Harmless stage props and 1d6 cp.



LIBRARY



Where We Left Off



This is a **standalone adventure**; no earlier events are assumed. You have arrived in **Bellwether**, a canal city celebrating its Festival of Small Wonders. Lantern Market is packed with merchants, performers, painted barges, and visitors. A string of coordinated pickpocket thefts has just disrupted the festivities, and the Canal Watch is looking for capable investigators. Some stolen property is valuable, while some is urgently personal.

What now?

Speak with the victims and witnesses in Lantern Market.

Reconstruct how several pickpockets worked together.

Decide what a fair resolution looks like once the culprits are found.

Public Notice — Festival Theft Inquiry

BELLWETHER CANAL WATCH

Property reported missing in Lantern Market:

- Jeweled blue purse containing coin and Festival Guild property
- Silver flower-shaped locket
- Apothecary packet labeled **VELL — HEART — SUNSET**
- Gold wedding ring engraved **M & D**

Information may be reported to **Sergeant Mina Cobble**. Return of necessary and sentimental property will be prioritized.

Festival Program — Small Wonders Stage

Time	Act
Noon	Clockwork Birds of East Lock
First Bell	The Incredible Folding Boat
Second Bell	Open Audition Slot — pending authorization
Sunset	Grand Canal Lantern Procession

Festival rule: Audience-participation acts must use marked props, bells, or volunteers. Unannounced removal of personal property is not a performance.

Recovered Property Claim Sheet

Item	Claimant	Identifying detail	Returned
Jeweled purse	Guildmaster Osric Pindle	Peacock-blue stones; Guild crest inside	☐
Silver locket	Tessa Thimblewick	Pressed violet under glass	☐
Medicine packet	Apothecary Vell	Red wax sun seal	☐
Wedding ring	Mara or Dain Lute	Engraved M & D	☐

Bellwether Lantern Market



A bright canal-side market of arched bridges, painted barges, lantern awnings, flower stalls, pastry carts, and street stages. (DM ADDITION)

Maestro Nibs



Director of the Nimble Nibs puppet troupe, recognizable by a patched plum tailcoat, tiny brass spectacles, and a conductor's baton. *(DM ADDITION)*

Sergeant Mina Cobble



A Bellwether Canal Watch sergeant with a weathered blue coat, brass badge, notebook, and dry sense of humor. (DM ADDITION)

Guildmaster Osric Pindle



Festival Guildmaster in peacock-blue brocade, known for his jeweled purse and strong opinions about permits. (*DM ADDITION*)

The Nimble Nibs Troupe



A goblin puppet-and-sleight-of-hand company whose costumes, marionettes, stage smoke, and quick fingers make every performance unpredictable. (DM ADDITION)

Bellwether Festival Stage



Bellwether's temporary canal-side stage, framed by festival banners, bridges, and lantern-lit barges. *(DM ADDITION)*

DM Quick Reference — The Nimble Nibs

Session 002 · Print and keep at the table · Full detail in file 1

Act / Scene Flow

Scene ID	Scene	Immediate cue	NPC disposition / motivation	Conditional trigger or effect	Encounter ref
Act I, Scene 1.1	The Pompous Victim	Osric reenacts theft; Mina names priority items	Osric: indignant, recover Guild key; Mina: amused, secure restitution	Publicly embarrass Osric → alarm; secure key clue/map → clean lead	None
Act I, Scene 1.2	Three Clues and a Custard Pie	Choose 2: Tessa, Pip, Niblet	Tessa: helpful/protect small goblin; Pip: defensive; Niblet: curious or afraid	Warn/chase lookout → troupe defensive; any clue still reaches impound yard	None
Act II, Scene 2.1	The Impound Yard Ledger	Wagon clamped; puppet trunk in Guild annex	Barnaby: procedural/face-saving; Niblet: tests trust	Legal path → 25 gp + audition; threat/robbery → Watch and defensive troupe	None
Act II, Scene 2.2	Beneath the Crooked Curtain	Stolen property catalogued during rehearsal	Maestro: grandiose/save troupe; Skritch: protective; Fizzwick: confess	Agreement → audition; capture → hearing; escape → public pursuit	Enc 1 optional
Act III, Scene 3.1	The Festival Audition	Crowd wants a show; officials want terms	Amara: credible festival; Osric: dignity; Mina: restitution	License, exile, arrest, or cover-up determined here	None
Act III, Scene 3.2	Pockets Emptied	Claims signed over café tables	Maestro: preserve troupe; Mina: close case accurately	Full restitution closes case; unresolved items become post-play loose ends	None

Pacing

- **Target:** 2–2.5 hours.
- **Act I, Scene 1.2:** Use two clue stations, not all three, unless players want a longer investigation.
- **Act II, Scene 2.2:** Skip Encounter 1 if a credible restitution offer is made.
- **Act III, Scene 3.2:** 5–10 minutes; no new obstacle.
- **Extended runtime:** 2.5–3 hours if every witness, public debate, and optional encounter runs fully.

Clue Matrix

Clue	Source	Reveals	Failure fallback
Thimble emblem	Dropped card / Tessa	Nimble Nibs; Old Puppet Quarter	Old playbill visible near market exit
Flour and straw trail	Pip / ground	Impound yard route	Mina points it out
Evidence tag	Niblet	Impounded puppet wagon	Chalk arrows reach municipal yard
Guild key description	Osric	Festival prop annex is target	Barnaby recognizes Guild crest later
Catalogued property	Cellar	Intent to return does not erase harm	Fizzwick confesses item locations

Restitution Priority

Priority	Item	Holder/location	Effect if returned
1	Heart medicine	Fizzwick's return basket	Mina lowers social DCs by 2
2	Wedding ring	Marionette crown	Couple withdraws complaint
3	Tessa's locket	Skritch's costume	Skritch supports surrender
4	Guild key/token	Catalogued purse basket	License can proceed
5	40 gp / purse	Catalogued basket	Osric pays full contract

Encounter 1 — De-escalation

- **Math:** 1,100 raw XP; ×2 for six enemies = 2,200 adjusted XP; Easy threshold 1,500.
- **Stop immediately if:** any two goblins incapacitated; Maestro persuaded; priority property displayed; credible lawful release offered; exits blocked without violence.
- **Round 1:** Open alley hatch; move property basket.
- **Round 2:** Maestro calls for parley.
- **Round 3:** Goblins at exits escape.
- **No lethal intent:** Tricks, nets, flour, padded props; never attack unconscious creatures.

NPC Behavior Priority

NPC	Priority 1	Priority 2	Break point
Maestro Nibs	Keep troupe together	Recover wagon/trunk	Medicine/ring harm shown → immediate restitution
Skritch	Protect younger goblins	Prove skill	Tessa's kindness mentioned → return locket
Fizzwick	Return urgent items	Perform finale	Private question → confess all locations
Mina	Vulnerable victims first	Proportionate justice	Excessive force → withhold reward
Osric	Recover key	Protect dignity	Sponsor credit → waive 25 gp fee
Barnaby	Protect procedure	Hide filing error	Face-saving correction → lawful release path
Amara	Safe popular act	Avoid scandal	Full restitution + marked props → license

Endings

Ending	How	Reputation	Loose end
Licensed restitution	Priority property returned; safe audition; officials persuaded	Watch and performers approve	Troupe owes community service
Restitution and exile	Property returned; no license	Fair but cautious	Troupe may recur elsewhere
Arrest	Troupe captured; Mina upholds charges	Merchants approve; performers disapprove	Fate of wagon and younger goblins
Public contest	Marked-token act succeeds before judgment	Party becomes festival sponsor	Osric claims credit
Cover-up	Party hides thefts or enables escape	Troupe grateful; Mina suspicious	Missing items/fraud inquiry
Escape	Troupe reaches stage or leaves city	Mixed, comic embarrassment	Recurring rivals with moral debt
Withdraw without ending	Party abandons case	No reward	Watch pursues case; festival slot closes

Debrief Payments

Item	Condition	Payer	Amount
Contract reward	Purse, key, token, and 40 gp returned	Osric	300 gp
Civic reward	Peaceful close + priority restitution	Canal Watch	Up to 200 gp
Release charge	Filing error exposed + provisional license	Troupe/party	25 gp cost; Osric may waive
Nimble Nibs contact	Licensed or fairly exiled	Troupe	Urban intelligence
Milestone	Only if inserted into a campaign	—	Earned; apply between sessions

Tone / Staging Beats

- Bells and repeated music turn the investigation into choreography.
- Osric's indignity is funny; stolen medicine and sentimental items are not.
- Barnaby's goat interrupts bureaucracy when pacing drags.
- Maestro describes scenes as acts; Skritch counts movements under her breath.
- Harmless smoke provides a pause before initiative, not an automatic fight.
- Let the crowd's laughter become approval only after restitution is addressed.

Loose Ends to Flag in Session Log After Play

- [] Which property was returned?
- [] Was the puppet wagon released, retained, or abandoned?
- [] Were the Nimble Nibs licensed, exiled, arrested, concealed, or escaped?
- [] Did Osric receive public credit or public embarrassment?
- [] What is Mina's final disposition toward the party?
- [] Does the party retain the Nimble Nibs as a contact or rival?
- [] Did any cover-up, unpaid victim, or property dispute remain unresolved?